

Microsoft Teams: A System Exploration

This paper explores all aspects of the Microsoft Teams system. From development to future advancements, Teams has been at the forefront of communication, collaboration, and data sharing software applications.

To start off, connecting users via an integrated platform that integrates voice and video conferences, instant messaging, and file-sharing features is the main goal of the Microsoft Teams interface. In order to improve cooperation and lessen dependency on numerous stand-alone apps, Microsoft created Teams to combine communication tools into a single, integrated workspace (Microsoft, n.d.). Users of the application can designate specific areas for certain groups or projects, allowing participants to exchange papers, hold meetings, and have well-structured conversations. In order to satisfy the increasing need for digital collaboration, Teams was developed from older communication platforms like Office Communicator and Skype, as stated by Microsoft (n.d.). Microsoft Teams enhances coordination, boosts productivity, and facilitates efficient communication for users in academic and professional contexts by integrating these features into a single interface.

Businesses, student organizations, classrooms, and remote employees are just a few of the many users that depend on Microsoft Teams' communication and coordination capabilities. Teams is used in professional settings to coordinate projects, hold meetings, and facilitate departmental collaboration via shared files and channels. With over 115 million daily users globally, Teams became the go-to tool for many companies looking to continue operations remotely during the COVID-19 outbreak (Maldow, n.d.). Similar to this, Teams is used by educators and students to facilitate online learning, share resources, and hold virtual discussions. However, studies indicate that although Teams is generally useful, its interface occasionally has usability issues that make it difficult to use (Al-Qora'n, Salem, & Gordon, 2022; Somesh, 2021). Because of its accessibility, Microsoft 365 integration, and capacity to unite disparate user groups for collaboration and education, Teams continues to be one of the most popular digital communication technologies in spite of these problems.

While the Microsoft Teams we know today is known for integrating voice and video chat with file shareability worldwide, the platform had much humbler beginnings. Back in March of 2009, Microsoft wanted to combine their current lineup of business applications with Cloud-accessible functionality, formally known as the Business Productivity Online Suite (BPOS) (Microsoft, n.d.). BPOS was effectively the first iteration of Teams, featuring household productivity apps such as Word and Excel, as well as early (and limited) communication functions through Office Communicator. The platform was a success, but it wouldn't skyrocket in use until 2011, when Microsoft purchased Skype. This acquisition brought a new level of real-time connection to the software and was accompanied by a rebrand to Office 365. Over the next few years, the need for better digital communication tools steadily rose and other players began to hit the market as connectivity technology progressed. In March of 2017, Google launched Hangouts Meet/Chat, putting them on the map in the desktop collaboration world. Shortly after, Microsoft Teams was announced as the successor to Office 365, and the platform began to see widespread use in a variety of business applications. However, there was much more to come. When the COVID-19

pandemic began to shut down in-person operations worldwide, governments and businesses alike turned to Teams as a front runner for communication alongside Zoom. This caused an unprecedented spike in traffic. Since this explosive growth, Teams remains cemented as one of the world's most seamless professional communication networks, and will likely continue to do so for the foreseeable future.

After understanding Microsoft Teams history, users, and purpose, it is critical to understand how Teams operates. Microsoft Teams can be downloaded on Windows, Mac, IOS, Android, and supported web browsers like Edge or Chrome. From there, someone can either join or create a "team". On a team, you can add members, create channels for different tabs, chat, share files, and schedule meetings. There are also integrations and advanced features such as Microsoft 365 integrations (Outlook, OneDrive, Sharepoint, etc.), collaborating on Word, Excel, and PowerPoint documents without leaving Teams, and a whiteboard feature where you can write and draw together. Additionally, features for breakout rooms and third-party app downloads are available. Entry information for each individual will go when they sign up for teams. The individual can also be invited to the team by the team owners, the person who created the team, or can be given guest access from a Teams client or Teams admin center, where they will use a guest account. The guest access can take up to twelve hours to be approved. Team owners can also create a code that members can use to join a team instead of inviting each person individually, and this method allows instant access. A member can have their role changed to owner by the original creator or someone whose role was previously switched to owner. A team can have up to a hundred owners. Owners manage members, announcements, and settings of the team. The features discussed above do not require any subscription; however, if the user does have a Microsoft 365 personal or family subscription, they have access to extra features such as unlimited group calls, up to 300 participants (100 without subscription), and group meetings for up to thirty hours.

Furthermore, shares exist within Microsoft Teams. According to Naveen Kumar, in his article for Demand Sage, Microsoft Teams Statistics 2025 (Users, Revenue, & Market Share), Teams has a "32.39% share of the global video conferencing market". Teams is second in the widely used platforms. This market share is higher than GoToMeeting, Google Meet, and WebEx (Kumar, 2025). Stakeholders include any organizations that depend on Teams as their communication platform. Microsoft Teams is unique because users can share files inline, organize conversations by project/department, collaboration within Teams, whiteboard feature integration with other Microsoft 365 applications, as well as third party tools.

Given Microsoft Teams' expanding user base, data/usability tests are essential to perform to understand how effectively users engage with the application's features. Users generally find its video calling features favorable, with its sharing functions receiving 4 out of 5 ratings and 5 out of 5s in a study published by UX Planet. On the other hand, despite reviewers agreeing that Teams has all the features of a well-balanced video conferencing application, the intuitiveness of its locations is lacking. The average time to complete a task was noted as 15-20 seconds, with excessive time and effort leading to errors. Errors were most noticeably caused by design language discrepancies, higher latency while interacting with the software, and violations of UX laws (Somesh 2021). This concept is further supported by a study completed by researchers Lamis Al-Qora'n, Omar Salem, and Neil Gordon, who utilized Nielsen's heuristics to evaluate

Teams from an educator's standpoint. Their findings agreed that while the application was generally user-friendly, it lacked key organization that would improve usability, leading to review scores averaging 3 out of 5. Their main critiques include insufficient user alerts, limited backtracking options, clustered button groupings, and an excessive cognitive load required to locate features. Despite Microsoft Teams' widespread use in academic and professional environments, the application has received average scores in many usability reviews, with common criticisms revolving around its complex interface.

Microsoft Teams continues to evolve with new features focused on artificial intelligence, user experience, and hybrid collaboration. Recent updates such as Copilot, an artificial intelligence assistant that can help with administrative tasks such as summarizing meetings or generating action items, and Microsoft Mesh, which allows 3D Virtual meetings through avatars, demonstrate Microsoft's push toward smarter and more engaging communication tools (Wavenet, 2025). However, research has noted that Teams can still feel cluttered and unintuitive, which slows user performance (Somesh, 2021; Al-Qora'n et al., 2022). Future improvements could include a cleaner interface, smarter notification control, and context-aware personalization that automatically adjusts features based on user roles (Alkhatib & Alainati, 2024). By emphasizing accessibility, streamlined design, and intelligent automation, Teams can continue progressing toward a more efficient and inclusive collaboration platform.

In conclusion, Microsoft Teams has transformed digital communication and collaboration by combining video chat, file sharing, messaging, artificial intelligence, and much more into one workspace. While Teams has an abundance of features and capabilities in one software, usability issues causing an increased mental workload still need to be addressed from a human factors perspective. As Teams continues to update and add to the systems features, its dominance in the market will continue to increase and further cements itself as a leader in the digital communication and collaboration space.

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